



◀ Female rebels

Victorious female soldiers wave from tanks arriving in Havana after the Cuban Revolution. Women's positions changed markedly for the better as a direct result of their participation in the revolution.



doctors, and even engineers. However, for all the communist rhetoric on gender equality, women still continued to be viewed primarily as mothers and wives.

Inspiring further revolutions

Russia's revolution of 1917 helped to inspire China's Cultural Revolution a decade later. The Communist Party of China also identified women's emancipation as a leading goal of its revolution, and Party commanders made concerted efforts to mobilize women in the 1930s and '40s. Chinese women were attracted by communist ideology, which advocated for the end of patriarchal practices such as arranged marriage and gender inequality in the family. In contrast to the Russian Revolution, after the communists seized power in 1949, the Marriage Law of the People's Republic of China established fundamental civil rights for women, including rights to vote, receive an education, and work outside of their homes.

The Cuban Revolution of 1959 also brought fundamental changes to the status of women. Cuba was arguably more successful than either China or Russia in incorporating women into educated and professional society. Today, Cuban women represent a majority in higher education, and the number of female lawyers, doctors, and scientists is among the highest in the world.



BIOGRAPHY

ZHANG QINQIU

Born in 1904, Zhang Qinqiu went on to become one of the first female members of China's Communist Party. In 1925, she studied at Moscow Sun Yat-sen University, becoming one of the 28 Bolsheviks educated there. In 1932, she became director of the General Political Department of the Fourth Front Army, the highest military position ever held by a woman. Zhang took her own life in 1968, after facing persecution as a scholar in China's Cultural Revolution.